

THE NARRATIVE FALLACY

The cause of the because—How to split a brain—Effective methods of pointing at the ceiling—Dopamine will help you win—I will stop riding motorcycles (but not today)—Both empirical and psychologist? Since when?

ON THE CAUSES OF MY REJECTION OF CAUSES

During the fall of 2004, I attended a conference on aesthetics and science in Rome, perhaps the best possible location for such a meeting since aesthetics permeates everything there, down to one's personal behavior and tone of voice. At lunch, a prominent professor from a university in southern Italy greeted me with extreme enthusiasm. I had listened earlier that morning to his impassioned presentation; he was so charismatic, so convinced, and so convincing that, although I could not understand much of what he said, I found myself fully agreeing with everything. I could only make out a sentence here and there, since my knowledge of Italian worked better in cocktail parties than in intellectual and scholarly venues. At some point during his speech, he turned all red with anger—thus convincing me (and the audience) that he was definitely right.

He assailed me during lunch to congratulate me for showing the effects of those causal links that are more prevalent in the human mind than in reality. The conversation got so animated that we stood together near the buffet table, blocking the other delegates from getting close to the food. He was speaking accented French (with his hands), I was answering in primitive Italian (with my hands), and we were so vivacious that the other guests were afraid to interrupt a conversation of such importance and animation. He was emphatic about my previous book on randomness, a sort of angry trader's reaction against blindness to luck in life and in the markets, which had been published there under the musical title *Giocati dal caso*. I had been lucky to have a translator who knew almost more about the topic than I did, and the book found a small following among Italian intellectuals. "I am a huge fan of your ideas, but I feel slighted. These are truly mine too, and you wrote the book that I (almost) planned to write," he said. "You are a lucky man; you presented in such a comprehensive way the effect of chance on society and the overestimation of cause and effect. You show how stupid we are to systematically try to *explain* skills."